

ASSABIAN RITES

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Sorcerous Lore, Spells and Skills for the Thennla Campaign Setting

Part Two: Alchemy in Assabia

In Part Two we are exploring the first of the specialist professions open to sorcerer characters. Sorcery in Assabia is such a diverse field that there are many specialisms available that provide opportunities to add a bit of colour and flavour to Player Characters and Non-Player Characters alike. Sorcerers may label themselves as Enchanters, Conjurers, Necromancers, Illusionists and so on. In many cases they are not necessarily practising an exclusive category of magic but rather have a clear focus to their art through which they differentiate themselves from the competition. After all, sorcerers have to support themselves, hence they have to make a business of their magic.

But here we are examining a true specialist, the Alchemist. This article offers additional information for character generation as well as the specialist spells and skills they have access to. The version of Alchemy presented here differs from Bruce Turner's rules provided in the Sorandib book. Nor is it necessary to consider this a replacement. The setting allows a great deal of variety in magic systems from one culture or region to the next.

Characteristically, Assabian alchemy has a sorcery spell, Transmute, as its core. It is not in any way connected with the mundane preparations available from a herbalist or apothecary. Whether or not Alchemy makes a suitable Player-Character profession in your game, it's good to know what potions and concoctions may be available for characters to buy – or to stumble across on their adventures, and how they are made.

An alchemist or the Alchemists' Guild of Djesmir is also a good potential patron, in need of brave and foolhardy adventurers to go out in search of some ingredient that definitely cannot be found on the market. If you want to send your adventurers to Monster Island, the Alchemists Guild are a good prospect to fund the trip.

Alchemist

The effects of Assabian alchemy are similar to conventional sorcery, however by storing magic in the form of Elixirs the alchemist can put magic at the disposal of others in a way a sorcerer cannot. Alchemists are experts in

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manipulation of the Natures (Fire, Water, Air, Stone and Flesh).

The 'science' of Alchemy is closely tied to Materialist philosophy, which explains its purpose as taking magically inert materials and giving them magical efficacy. There are Alchemists with a passion for dimensionalism who view their work as liberating magical properties that lie dormant. The ultimate goal for both schools of thought is to one day achieve this with a living organism.

Alchemy can be immensely lucrative, but the barriers to entry are significant. The set-up costs of an alchemist's workshop, from bricks and mortar to equipment, run to many thousands of dinars. The material components for each formula are also usually very expensive and hard to acquire.

Alchemist

- **Standard Skills:** Customs, Deceit, Influence, Insight, Locale, Perception, Willpower
- **Professional Skills:** Alchemy, Commerce, Invocation (Alchemist's Formulary), Language (Any), Literacy, Lore (Mundane Arcana), Rites (Assabian)

Alchemy is an intensive field of study, so it is difficult for a sorcerer who spends her time on spellcasting to acquire more than the most basic acquaintance with it, or for a dedicated alchemist to also master several grimoires of spells. The Alchemist has a specialised version of the Shaping skill, Alchemy, which is used to manipulate the product of the Transmute spell rather than the spell itself.

Alchemy (INT+ POW)

Alchemy is the skill of combining ingredients to create a magically imbued substance, or Elixir, in accordance with a known formula. In most instances the Alchemy skill is not rolled, but used as Shaping to manipulate the magical

process represented by the Transmute sorcery spell. As with Shaping, the Alchemist has a number of points to allocate to manipulation equal to one tenth of her Alchemy skill. Each manipulation costs an additional Magic Point, as with any sorcery spell casting. The available manipulations are:

- **Conditions.** Each point of Alchemy applied to Conditions allows the alchemist to limit the effect of the Elixir by one statement concerning upon who, or what, or when it will (or will not) take effect. Conditions may also be used to specify a trait for the Elixir – such as a colour, texture, odour or taste (or lack thereof), concentration, or any anything else the Games Master will agree to.
- **Magnitude.** The Alchemist ensures the Elixir has the required strength to overcome magical defences.
- **Doses.** The alchemist can produce an additional dose of the Elixir from the same ingredients for each point allocated;
- **Combinations.** For each point allocated the Alchemist can combine one or more alchemical formulae together to produce a complex range of effects;
- **Shelf Life.** Alchemical products are inherently unstable. However the

Elixir Shelf-Life Table	
<i>Shaping Cost</i>	<i>Shelf Life of Product</i>
0	POW Hours
1	POW x 3 Hours
2	POW Days
3	POW x 3 Days
4	POW Weeks
5	POW x 3 Weeks
6	POW Months
7	POW x 3 Months
8	POW Years
9	POW x 3 Years
10	POW x 10 years

Alchemist can extend the time for which the Elixir will keep its potency.

At the end of its shelf life an Elixir is no longer effective. With some rare exceptions, the Shelf Life does not alter the duration of the effect of the Elixir once it is used.

Alchemical elixirs can be liquids, gases, solids – potions for ingestion, grains to be burned and inhaled, a cauldron full of liquid in which to dip the object (or person) to be affected, a set of paints to daub onto the target.

Antidotes

When creating an Elixir an alchemist can also create an antidote that will neutralise its effects. To create an antidote to an Elixir requires adding Doses to create the required total quantity of elixirs and antidotes. So to create two doses of a potion and two doses of its antidote requires 3 points of Alchemy; and using Conditions to state how the antidote will counteract the elixir. Unless otherwise specified by the Alchemist the effect of the antidote is immediate and no resistance roll is made.

Formularies

Alchemist Grimoires are known as Formularies, which contain the instructions and components required to create elixirs. A Formulary must contain the Transmute spell, but may also contain other spells which are useful to their trade.

TRANSMUTE

Concentration, Resist (Endurance), Ritual

Transmute is typically found as part of a Master Formulary. The sorcerer casts this spell on a collection of ingredients to transform them into an alchemical compound or elixir. Any living creature unfortunate enough to be listed among the ingredients is entitled to an Endurance resistance roll. The dice roll should

also be recorded as it will serve as the Potency of the Elixir where resistance rolls are allowed.

Procedure

Alchemy is a time-consuming business, and the Transmute spell is just the climactic moment of many hours spent preparing and processing the components. Luckily, this kind of work can often be delegated to an Alchemist's assistants. As a general rule, assume that the rarity of the components also reflects the complexity of the procedures that must be followed. Preparing an alchemical transmutation that requires only Common components may typically take hours. Where rare components are involved, days. For Exotic assume weeks and for Fabled, months.

Alchemy Preparation Times	
Components	Prep Time
Common	1d6 hours
Rare	1d6 x 3 hours
Exotic	1d6 days
Fabled	1d6 x 3 days

Of course an alchemist needs a place of work, and as the work can be hazardous and create evil-smelling gases and deeply unpleasant residues, this is best removed from proximity to people who are able to press complaints. Given the high value of the components and products, and the disastrous impact of a process ruined before it is complete, the alchemist's place of work may also need to be very secure.

Example Formulae

Many sorcery spells can be emulated through Alchemy. Some can only be achieved with the help of an Alchemist – Hide Life for example.

In most cases the duration of the effect once applied is equal to the Alchemist's POW in minutes, and cannot be further manipulated, unless the Alchemist uses Conditions to further limit the effect.

On the other hand where a Resistance Roll is called for the victim's roll is usually Endurance instead of Willpower.

Components

In each case a formula is stated to be Common (C), Rare (R), Exotic (E) or Fabled (F). This indicates the complexity of the preparation, and also how difficult and how expensive it is to acquire the components required – whether that is ingredients or specialised equipment that will be consumed in the process. The timescales suggested are for requests for materials made via the Alchemists' Guild of Djesmir.

Common. The required components are usually available in any large town or city. Cost d6x10 Dinars

Rare. At least some of the components are hard to find and require a specialist supplier. There may be a wait of 1d4 weeks while components are sourced. Cost d6 x 25 Dinars

Exotic. At least some of the components have to be acquired via long distance trade, perhaps from a single source. There may be a wait of 1d4 months while components are sourced. Cost d6 x 50 Dinars

Fabled. At least one component can only be acquired by going on a quest to find it (or sending someone else). Cost d6 x 500 Dinars

So long as there is a willing buyer, alchemical elixirs typically can be sold for between three and five times the cost of the components.

Alchemist's Glue (C)

A substance that replicates the Holdfast sorcery spell. If no conditions are applied, then Alchemist's Glue will react when applied to two surfaces which are then brought together. If Conditions are used it can be applied to a single surface and will stick anything that subsequently comes into contact with it that meets the Conditions. In this case it will remain

potent for as long as its Shelf Life, but once triggered it will hold fast for the Duration, in hours.

Alchemist's Amberglass (R)

The Alchemist creates a glassy paste which hardens into crystalline form, and which can serve as a vessel to hold a spirit that is compelled to enter the Amberglass, usually with the Dominate sorcery spell. The Spirit may then be safely removed to a safe place and disposed of if it is causing a nuisance, or perhaps held for future use. Once trapped in the Amberglass, the spirit's resistance rolls to further Dominate spells are always at Hard difficulty. If Conditions are used to restrict the Amberglass' capacity so that it can contain only certain spirit types, this becomes Formidable. The Precision gift (see below) can be used to raise this to Hopeless. Only one spirit can be trapped per crystal at a time and the POW of the trapped spirit cannot exceed three times the Intensity of the Transmute spell.

Amberglass crystals can in fact vary in colour, as the alchemist can use a Condition to set the appearance. A crystal with a spirit trapped inside will glow gently. When the shelf life of the crystal expires, and spirit trapped within is automatically released. Amberglass crystals can be reused so long as they have Shelf-Life remaining.

Balm of Regeneration (C)

When applied to an injury or wound this balm will provide the immediate stabilisation benefits of the *Regenerate* sorcery spell. Hit points equal to the Intensity will be regenerated over the subsequent hour after which the preparation has no further effect.

Elixir of Disenchantment (E)

An Elixir contained in a bath or large cauldron that will permanently unravel the magical enchantment in any item or object immersed in it if the Magnitude is less than its own. A temporary enchantment (charm), or any ensorcelled object, person or creature, can

have all active magic effects permanently nullified or banished. In the case of permanent Enchantments the Intensity of the Transmute spell with which the Elixir is created must also exceed the total of Characteristic or Attribute points invested in the enchantment's creation. The disenchantment process takes at least one hour of immersion per magical effect, trait or spell being removed. The Elixir remains effective for the whole of its Shelf Life, but with each use will lose 1 point of Magnitude until it is rendered inert.

Elixir of Undeath (F)

A potion that transforms the drinker into an Undead creature (per the Undeath spells) for a duration that increases with each dose. Typical conditions include that the state of Undeath only persists between sunset and sunrise, however whenever on/off conditions apply the subject, if unwilling, can resist each occurrence. The first dose of this Elixir will last POW Hours, the second POW Days, the third POW Weeks, the fourth POW Months and the fifth POW Years. An Alchemist with the Refinement gift can increase the duration of each dose by one step, making the fifth permanent.

Embalming Fluid of Revivification (R)

Then alchemist undertakes to embalm a corpse of some kind and through alchemical transmutation revivifies the corpse in direct emulation of the Sorcery spell Revivify, with a Duration equal to the Shelf Life of the Elixir. An Alchemist with the Refinement gift can make this effect permanent.

Liquor of Manna (R)

A simple potion that emulates the Store Manna sorcery spell. The liquor retains its potency (including any Magic Points placed within) for the duration of its Shelf Life, at which point it becomes inert and any remaining Magic Points stored are dissipated.

Ointment of Animal Attraction (C)

The alchemical version of Draw (Creatures) relies on the senses of the target creatures for its range, as does its reverse, the Ointment of Animal Repulsion, but conversely is not limited in its effects to a maximum SIZ of three times Intensity. While the components for this formula are noted as Common, in reality they become harder to find the more exotic the creatures to be attracted.

Oil of Animal Form (R)

When smeared over the body, this elixir replicates the Shapechange (to Creature) sorcery spell. The Duration is measured in hours, however the Alchemist can use Conditions to adjust the duration of the effect to be triggered and/or ended by sunrise or sunset.

Ointment of Dark Sight (C)

Emulating the *Perceive (Night Vision)* sorcery spell, when smeared around the user's eyes this ointment grants the ability to see in the dark. The effect will negate one grade of difficulty imposed by low light conditions for every 3 Intensity.

Many similar preparations exist that bestow other senses, but may require much rarer components.

Potions of Abjuration (varies)

This Elixir emulates the *Abjure (Substance/Process)* spell. For example, a Potion of Breathlessness (C) allows the user to go without air. A Potion of Lifelessness (R) allows the user to forgo all bodily needs and processes and convincingly feign death for a Duration measured in hours. A Potion of Youthful Vigor (E) prevents physical ageing for POW years, and a Potion of Mental Acuity does the same for POW and INT. An exotic (F) version apparently transfers its remaining shelf life to the user.

Potions of Endangerment (R)

This potion emulates the relevant *Attract (Threat)* sorcery spell. Depending on the threat concerned it may come in very different forms.

Potion of Flight (F)

A potion that replicates the Sorcery spell Fly. The allocation of Intensity to increased Movement is entirely dependent on the SIZ of the user.

Potion of Speed (C)

Drinking this potion grants the effect of the Sorcery spell *Haste*.

Salve of Reflection (C)

Imbided or spread all over the target person or object, this elixir emulates the *Castback* sorcery spell.

The Alchemist's Revenge (R)

Versions exist that can be imbided or inhaled, this deadly elixir emulates the *Smother* sorcery spell.

Tincture of Damage Enhancement (R)

This Elixir is typically some kind of tincture smeared onto a weapon, or into which a weapon is dipped. Each dose will affect up to five missiles such as arrows, slingshot or crossbow bolts; or one melee weapon. The Duration in minutes begins from the moment the Elixir is applied.

Wines of (Characteristic) Distinction (R)

Each of these wines imparts the effects of an *Enhance (Characteristic)* spell on the drinker. Formulae that work on INT and POW require Exotic components.

Womb of Kabibahal (E)

This Elixir amounts to an entire vat full of liquid, large enough for a human body to reform in. The Womb of Kabibahal is the necessary component of the *Hide Life* sorcery spell. When a body reforms after an otherwise fatal event it does so within the Womb. The reformed beneficiary only continues to

regenerate while submerged in the elixir, and the process is halted if they leave. Kabibahal himself pioneered this technique and is said to still maintain a small facility in Djesmir with several vats leased out to paying customers.

Zlotar's Sweetmeats of Enfeeblement (E)

Eating these little candied sweets will reproduce the effect of the *Diminish (Characteristic)* sorcery spell.

Acquiring New Formulae

Learning a new formula is similar to Learning new spells (see Mythras core rules), with a cost of 3 experience rolls and a month of time and study. Even once a formula is learned, if denied access to the written formula when creating an Elixir the alchemist faces a penalty to their Alchemy skill of one grade (Hard) for formulae using Common or Rare components, two grades (Formidable) for Exotic and three (Herculean) for Fabled, affecting the amount of points of manipulation they have available.

While most formulae are acquired through proper channels via the Alchemists' Guild, anyone who has the Alchemy skill can make use of or learn a formula that they acquire by fair means or foul – assuming they also are literate in the language it is written in. Nevertheless alchemical formulae are incomprehensible to someone who does not have the Alchemy skill, and useless to someone who does not have the Transmute spell.

An enterprising alchemist can research a formula for themselves given enough time and money. This can be conducted in play using the Task rules in Mythras, with a task round duration measured in Weeks for a Common formula, Months for Rare, Seasons for Exotic and Years for fabled. Research is conducted using the Alchemy skill augmented by the alchemist's Lore (Mundane Arcana) skill.

The Alchemists' Guild of Djesmir

Most alchemists belong to a guild. The major guild is the Alchemists' Guild of Djesmir, and branches are to be found across the region. Many alchemists are also members of a sorcery order, but the status of the craft within these orders is vary varied – from a super-secret branch of research to a dead-end department staffed by people who don't get invited to parties.

History

The guild was created more than two centuries ago to share knowledge and techniques of alchemy between like-minded practitioners. Its earliest practical functions amounted to correspondence courses in Alchemy and Materialist philosophy. However it was soon the case that its most important function was to provide a support network for alchemists who need to get their hands on hard-to-find ingredients and highly specialised equipment. A lively and long-established referral network operated through the guild means that almost anything an alchemist may need can be acquired – so long as there is time and money enough to acquire it. This is in no small part because the guild has managed to maintain its foothold in Sharranket even after the people there did away with their Sultans.

Nature

The Alchemists' Guild of Djesmir provides its members with a range of essential contacts and services, as well as a set of rules of association that are variously adhered to and policed from one branch office to the next. It is firmly Materialist in its outlook, and rejects the teachings of the dimensionalist alchemists of Morkesh except when there is a suspicion they are on to some new formula.

Organisation

The highest ranks of the guild (Grand Master) are reserved for members resident in the Holy City of Djesmir. While these worthies regard themselves as masters of a powerful network spanning Assabia, the local chapters in Perlak, Ankwar, Khorala, Jelhai and Morkar are very small, one or two dozen members of all ranks between them, and only Morkar can boast more than one Master. Outside of these are a variety of private individuals, known as Correspondents (associate members), who deal directly with head office in Djesmir rather than their local representatives. In Sharranket the local chapter, based at Shimir and with offices at Homora, is particularly powerful because it brings access to exotic materials sourced in the far West by Sharranketan merchantmen, opening a whole new chapter of alchemical possibilities. That said, the Alchemists of Shimir are also under the wing of the Court of Ways, the local order of sorcery.

Membership

Standard. Common members are made up of amateurs known as Correspondents. These are usually very well-heeled hobbyists, since enrolling as a Correspondent (directly with the guild headquarters in Djesmir) involves a payment of a sum unimaginable to most people, usually in the region of 1,000 dinars. In return the Correspondent is sent a set of basic equipment and a formulary (which includes the Transmute spell and 1d3 formulae) and a prepacked set containing a range of Common ingredients and one or two rare ones. Also included is a letter of introduction from a journeyman member with whom to correspond for further help and instruction. Correspondents are invited to make use of guild training and purchase more equipment, supplies and formulae but are denied access to higher guild secrets and forbidden to trade as alchemists in any place where the guild is active. Progression through the ranks of the

guild to Journeyman, Master and Grand Master requires the member be a professional practising alchemist, beginning their career as an indentured apprentice.

Restrictions

Members of the guild are strictly forbidden to reveal trade secrets to any non-member, or any member not entitled to the information by their rank. No applicant for membership will be admitted if known to have a passion for Dimensionalism, and If an existing member of the guild is discovered to have such a passion there may be steps taken to expel them.

Skills

Alchemy, Commerce, Invocation (Alchemist's Formulary), Lore (Locale), Lore (Mundane Arcana), Willpower

Magic

Folk Magic: No Folk Magic teaching is offered to Correspondents. Apprentices usually have access to Folk Magic spells such as Chill, Cleanse, Dry, Glue, Heat, Perfume, Witchsight.

Sorcery: Sense (Substance), Transmogrify (to Substance), Transmute.

Alchemical Formulae: Any. As a rule Formulae requiring Exotic components are only made available to members of at least Journeyman rank or higher, and formulae requiring Fabled components are only made available to members of Master rank or higher.

Gifts (Trade Secrets)

A Journeyman Alchemist can acquire the following gift:

Customisation: The Alchemist can always incorporate one Condition without spending a Magic Point or manipulation points to do so.

A Master Alchemist may acquire the following Gifts:

Concentration: The Alchemist can make a more potent version of a formula, increasing the Intensity of the end product by 3.

Concession: The Alchemist is granted the exclusive right to sell a specific elixir to paying customers.

Precision: Used in conjunction with one or more Conditions defining who or what the Elixir will affect, this Gift allows the alchemist to so precisely target an intended victim that any resistance roll is at one grade of difficulty harder, or easier, as desired by the alchemist.

Refinement: The Alchemist can alter a formula to extend the duration of its effect from minutes to hours, hours to weeks, etc.

Allies and Enemies

The guild is opposed to any dimensionalist nonsense, but of course secretly covets any formulae devised by their dimensionalist rivals. The Second Master of the Morkar branch office is specifically tasked with stealing rivals' trade secrets. The chief object of his attention is the Unmakers of Zoridi Street, a dimensionalist brotherhood that practices Alchemy in Largil.

The guild is usually close to local sorcery orders, but is particularly beholden to the Court of Ways in Shimir.

Coming Up Next...

Enchantment – the creation of temporary charms, permanent enchantments that outlive the sorcerer and the crafting of Object of Virtue.